



SCHOOL OF ENGLISH
THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG

ENGL7605 PLAYFUL CREATION: MEANINGFUL GAME DESIGN

Semester: 2

Credits: 6

Contact hours per week: 2

Form of assessment: 100% coursework

Location & Time: Wednesday, 12:00-13:50, CPD-LG.61

Instructors:

Dr Benjamin Horn, Lecturer
Email: bhorn@hku.hk

Mr. Keith Bouchard, Teaching Assistant
Email: keithb@hku.hk

Course description:

This introductory course investigates how we can embody the spirit of meaningful, creative play into the design of games. In the world today, games have become a pervasive part of our lives, not only for leisure but also in the form of “gamified” labour. In this context, what does it mean to design a game that goes beyond entertainment to offer a meaningful, transformative experience for the player? To answer this question, students will embark on a journey encompassing the meticulous crafting of game worlds, the delicate balancing of gameplay systems, and the lively performance of roleplaying sessions, among others. Weekly readings will inform the students’ participation in class workshops, leading up to the final production of a game demo. No programming will be needed for the course. No prior experience with games is necessary.

Course objectives:

- Familiarize students with the core concepts of game design.
- Elevate students’ critical thinking skills with the introduction of foundational theories from the field of game studies.
- Develop students’ practical skillset for the creation of meaningful, creative games.

Course learning outcomes (CLOs):

CLO1: Identify and build upon different aspects of game design such as space, characters, and narrative

CLO2: Critically comment on foundational theories from game studies and how they apply to game design

CLO3: Develop ludic mastery over multiple digital software input formats and platforms

CLO4: Innovate a polished game deliverable that could be used as the basis for a professional pitch

Course organisation:

The course will be held on a weekly basis in the form of two-hour interactive lectures and gameplay workshops, with class-time evenly split between them. Workshops will consist of design challenges and gameplay analysis.

Moodle: The course Moodle site is the main portal for your individual learning through the semester. You will also upload your written assignments on Moodle (via Turnitin).

Readings: Course readings will be available on Moodle for download. Students must complete weekly readings in order to make the most of class.

Assessment:

Assessment method	Brief description	Weighting (%)	Aligned course learning outcome(s)
Participation	Students will be expected to make valuable and active contributions to class rather than lapse into silent passivity.	10%	CLOs 3-4
Weekly Quizzes	Students will be given weekly in-class quizzes to test their knowledge of course materials.	15%	CLOs 1-2
Midterm: In-Class Analysis Essay	Students will individually write an analysis essay responding to a question exploring how game design can be made meaningful, based on course discussions and materials related to the formal academic study of games.	35%	CLOs 1-2
Final: Game Demo	Individually or in pairs, students will submit a game demo. The game demo can be submitted as ONE of the following: (1) a detailed game design document, (2) a non-digital physical prototype with accompanying rulebook, or (3) a digital prototype.	40%	CLOs 3-4

Note: The Final will be submitted via Turnitin on Moodle on or before the due date. Please note that late submissions will result in a deduction from the grade.

Course content and tentative teaching schedule:

Week	Date	Topic/reading/activity
1	Jan. 21	Course Intro & Design Fundamentals <i>Reading</i> : Salen, K. and Zimmerman, E. (2003). <i>Rules of Play</i> . United Kingdom: MIT Press.
2	Jan. 28	Gameplay Genres: What Kind of Game Is It, Anyway? <i>Reading</i> : Vargas-Iglesias, J. (2020). Making Sense of Genre:

		The Logic of Video Game Genre Organization. <i>Games and Culture</i> , 15(2), 158-178.
3	Feb. 4	Working on a Game: The Developer Story <i>Reading:</i> Kerr, A. (2017). <i>Global Games: Production, Circulation and Policy in the Networked Era</i> . New York: Routledge.
4	Feb. 11	The Art of Tutorialisation: Starting off Strong <i>Reading:</i> Andersen, E., O'Rourke, E., Liu, Y. E., Snider, R., Lowdermilk, J., Truong, D., Cooper, S. and Popovic, Z. (2012). The impact of tutorials on games of varying complexity. In <i>Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems</i> (pp. 59-68).
5	Feb. 25	Location, Location, Location: Designing Game Spaces <i>Reading:</i> Vella, D. (2015). No Mastery Without Mystery: <i>Dark Souls</i> and the Ludic Sublime. <i>Game Studies</i> , 15(1).
6	Mar. 4	The NPC Charm: Creating Compelling Characters <i>Reading:</i> Scriven, P. (2023). A Social Phenomenology of Non-Player Characters (NPCs) in Videogames. <i>Techné: Research in Philosophy & Technology</i> , 27(2), 240.
7	Mar. 18	The Avatar: Who am I? <i>Reading:</i> Klevjer, R. (2022). <i>What is the Avatar?</i> Transcript Verlag.
8	Mar. 25	MIDTERM
9	Apr. 1	On the Path to Adventure: Quest Design <i>Reading:</i> Howard, J. (2008). <i>Quests: Design, Theory, and Practice</i> . A K Peters/CRC Press.
10	Apr. 8	Hidden Information: The User Experience <i>Reading:</i> Jørgensen, K. (2013). <i>Gameworld Interfaces</i> . MIT Press.
11	Apr. 15	Game Over: The Pleasure of Tragedy <i>Reading:</i> Leino, O. (2012). Death Loop as a Feature. <i>Game Studies</i> , 12(2).

12	Apr. 22	Easter Eggs: Transgressive Design <i>Reading: James, E.A. (2018). Queer Easter Eggs and their Hierarchies of Play. <i>Game Studies</i>, 18(3).</i>
13	Apr. 29	FINAL GAME DEMOS

Plagiarism Notice:

Definitions

The University's definitions on "plagiarism" are as follows:

Plagiarism refers to "direct copying of textual material or wilful use of other people's data and ideas, and presenting them as one's own without acknowledgement, whether or not such materials, data and ideas have been published" (Paragraph 6, HKU's ["Regulations Governing Students' Academic Conduct Concerning Assessment"](#)).

In other words, a person is committing plagiarism if he/she paraphrases or quotes the work of another person without clearly identifying (according to academic conventions) the borrowed material and documenting its source.

Self-plagiarism refers to "reuse of one's own data or repeat of previously published written work, or part thereof, in a 'new' publication without acknowledging that the data set has been used or written work has been published elsewhere" (Paragraph 3.1, HKU's ["Policy on Research Integrity"](#)). For instance, if a student re-uses largely or fully the contents of his/her past assignment submitted elsewhere and without acknowledging so in the "new" assignment, it can constitute self-plagiarism.

Plagiarism is a very serious offence and it is strictly prohibited in all assignments and examinations: "A candidate shall not engage in plagiarism nor employ nor seek to employ any other unfair means at an examination or in any other form of assessment" (Paragraph 6, HKU's ["Regulations Governing Students' Academic Conduct Concerning Assessment"](#)).
Students must use proper citations and provide sources wherever necessary.

If you aren't sure whether to cite it or not: CITE IT!

Protocol on the Handling of Plagiarism

There are severe penalties for plagiarism in the School of English. Students found plagiarizing may be failed not only in the plagiarized oral or written assignment but in the course. Their case will also be considered by a School panel which may decide on further penalties depending on the gravity of the offence. This may involve disclosure of the plagiarism committed to teachers of other courses within the School. The panel may also decide to lodge a complaint with the University's Disciplinary Committee which can result in other penalties. For details, please refer to the ["Protocol on the Handling of Plagiarism"](#).

Guidelines

There are clear university guidelines in the ["What Is Plagiarism"](#) booklet. Students should read these guidelines carefully and revisit them from time to time, especially before submitting an assignment. Ignorance about the nature and definition of plagiarism is never an

excuse and will not be accepted. The School of English prepared the [“Guidelines for Citing and Documenting Sources”](#) (PDF) for students to download.

Originality Checking of Assignments

Please read HKU’s [Turnitin](#) webpage for information on this originality checking engine, which “offers originality checking on students' work for proper citation or potential plagiarism. Once a paper is submitted to Turnitin, it will compare with documents in a continuously updated database consisting of current and archived web pages, millions of student papers worldwide, and collections of newspapers, magazines, scholarly journals, e-Books and e-Texts”.

Policy on Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

As a general rule, the **uncited** use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) is strictly prohibited, and will be considered as plagiarism. Students who do choose to use AI to modify their assignments **must** keep a record of their interactions with the AI (e.g. any changes made to the assignment by the AI) and submit it along with the assignment as an Appendix. The AI should also be cited both in-text and in the Bibliography of the assignment. When in doubt about your usage, please consult with your course convenor.

Course grade descriptors:

A+, A, A-	Excellent result. A thorough grasp of the subject as demonstrated by original, creative or exceptionally astute analysis and synthesis of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Ample evidence of familiarity with relevant reading and research as well as very effective organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills as appropriate to the assessment task. Students display excellent communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
B+, B, B-	Good to very good result. A good to very good grasp of the subject as demonstrated by generally persuasive analysis and synthesis of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Some evidence of a generally sound understanding of relevant reading and research as well as effective organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills as appropriate to the assessment task. Students display good to very good communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
C+, C, C-	Satisfactory to reasonably good result. A reasonable grasp of the subject as demonstrated by some analysis of ideas or interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Familiarity with relevant reading and research is adequate but tends to be rather descriptive with little evidence of critical reflection but organizational, rhetorical and presentation skills, as appropriate to the assessment task, still contribute to overall coherence satisfactorily. Students display reasonable communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
D+, D	Barely satisfactory result. A minimal grasp of the subject with little analysis

	of ideas or critical interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. Hardly any evidence of familiarity with relevant reading or research as required for the assessment task. Ideas presented are generally not well organized or well argued but still largely comprehensible. Students display minimal communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies.
F	Unsatisfactory result. A poor grasp of the subject with negligible or largely inaccurate analysis of ideas or interpretation of texts/issues/other course content or reflection on learning experience. A general lack of familiarity with relevant reading or research, as required for the assessment task. Work presented is poorly organized, largely irrelevant and incoherent. Work fails to reach the level expected for a master's curriculum. Students display poor communication skills in areas such as grammar, vocabulary, oral and aural competencies. Plagiarism or non-submission of coursework will also result in a Fail.

Points of contact:

For lecture-related enquiries, please contact the respective course instructors. Regarding assessment and any tutorial arrangements, please contact your tutor. Otherwise, your primary points of contact are:

Ms Hayley Wong, School of English Executive Officer
Email: hayleyhw@hku.hk Tel: 3917 7278

If you face difficulties in using any of the Internet services, including the Moodle class site, please contact the Information Technology Services (ITS) (Email: ithelp@hku.hk; Tel: 3917 0123). Please visit the ITS web page for their opening hours.

In all email enquiries, please specify the course code and title, and include your full name, nickname (if applicable), and your programme (MACC/MFA).

Students are welcome to schedule appointments with the course instructors and tutors at any point during the semester. All appointments are expected to be scheduled by email.